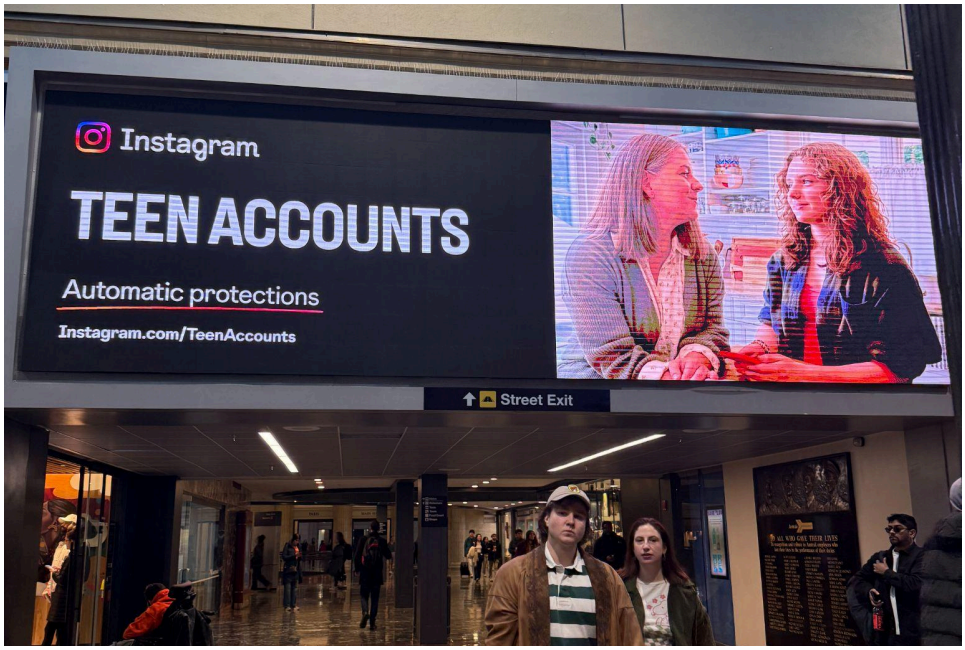
Brittany Huynh

ENGL393 Technical Writing

Rhetorical Analysis of Instagram Advertisement

March 2, 2026



Rhetoric is classically known as the art of persuasion. The message, audience, and purpose of a rhetorical piece are important because they determine how it should be crafted. Rhetorical appeals such as pathos and kairos can enhance how persuasive a piece can be. Billboards use rhetorical elements to effectively deliver a message and get the audience to follow an intended purpose. This paper breaks down the rhetorical elements used in a billboard advertisement for Instagram teen accounts and explains why the rhetoric is effective.

This billboard is located in Union Station in Washington, DC in a high-traffic area. It's above a strip of shops and is clearly visible when entering the station from the train. It's an advertisement for the social media platform Instagram's teen accounts option. The billboard has a simplistic and sleek design, much like Instagram's in-app interface, with a picture of an adult mother and teen daughter smiling at each other. It includes Instagram's familiar logo along with little text, including the phrase "Teen Accounts" in large bold letters, and underneath it the phrase "Automatic protections" underlined.

Information about the audience influences the appearance, tone, and diction of a piece of writing, therefore it is a key rhetorical element. In this billboard, the audience is likely not teenagers because they are known to want more autonomy and freedom over their choices rather than restriction. For this reason, this billboard is directed towards parents who have teenage children that use social media. Specifically, parents who want to protect their teenage children from the dangers of social media by monitoring their online behavior and activity. The creators of teen accounts and the billboard know this information about their audience, which is why the billboard is designed the way it is.

The underlying message of a piece of writing can relate to a problem or issue. The message is useful when figuring out the purpose of a piece of writing. The purpose can be determined based on what the message is. In this billboard, the underlying message is that teenagers and children are vulnerable to harm on social media. Social media content can be sensitive, offensive, or vulgar. Developing children are vulnerable to catfishing, phishing attacks and cyberbullying. Since the billboard includes only a few words, the creators of the billboard probably assumed that the audience already knows this message. Therefore, the phrases “Teen Accounts” and “Automatic Protections” are effective enough to get the message across.

The purpose of a piece of writing may be to drive the audience to take some form of action or draw awareness to a topic. In this billboard, the purpose is most likely to get the audience to use Instagram’s teen accounts. The purpose could also be to draw awareness to Instagram’s teen accounts. The designers of the billboard tailored the purpose to the message that teenagers and children are vulnerable on social media. Knowing the message, parents are encouraged to take preventative measures to protect their teens.

A rhetorical element that the billboard implies is pathos, or an emotional appeal to the audience. The target audience of this advertisement is parents, shown by the image of the mother and daughter. In the image, the two are smiling at one another, invoking feelings of tenderness and care, emotions that are prevalent in a parent-child relationship. The phrase "Automatic protections" invokes a sense of protectiveness, another emotion that parents feel for their children. This phrase persuades parents to use teen accounts in order to protect their children from inappropriate content and potential dangers on social media. Also, it encourages parents to choose Instagram over other platforms since it offers this restricted option for children and teenagers. The advertisement appeals to the emotions of parents through the image of the smiling mother and daughter and the phrase "Automatic protections."

Kairos is a rhetorical element that focuses on timing or the opportune moment to present an idea. This billboard is located in Union Station, a bustling train station that connects major commuter railways in and out of the DC metropolitan area. The billboard itself is not a static image, it's a dynamic screen that changes advertisements every five minutes or so. The image of the billboard was taken at 5:00pm on a Saturday, one of the busiest times of the week for Union Station. The Instagram billboard could only show during Union Station's highest traffic times. The placement and timing of the billboard are highly effective at gaining the attention of anyone visiting Union Station. A large portion of regular Union Station commuters could be adults who are parents to teenagers. Therefore, the usage of the Kairos appeal in this billboard effectively reaches the target audience.

In conclusion, the billboard draws attention to the message that teenagers are susceptible to harm on social media using just a few phrases. This message is directed to an audience that is parents to teenagers who use social media. The purpose of the billboard is to get parents to use

Instagram teen accounts to protect and monitor their children's online activity. The purpose is enhanced using the rhetorical appeals pathos and kairos. Pathos is used to appeal to parents' emotions of protectiveness and care for their children. Kairos is used by the placement and timing of the advertisement to reach the target audience. Although the design is simplistic, the rhetoric of the billboard is effective at presenting the message to the target audience.